

Attachment 1

SOW REQUIREMENTS

Vanilla × Comedia - Design SOW

Date: April 2, 2026

From: Comedia Design Inc.

Status: SOW for Design Work

What We Heard on March 16

A few things shifted meaningfully from the January conversation and the original proposal.

- Sam: Get to building fast. Skip the months of audit-heavy discovery. Value from week one.
- Gene: Three clear priorities. Fix the foundational IA/nav, layer in the proactive AI coach, future-proof for expansion beyond estate planning.
- Sam (added): The "dead zones" problem - parts of the app that can't be populated with AI inputs today. No universal input/output pattern exists yet.

Revised Approach

We compress discovery into the first two weeks - not zero discovery, but fast discovery. You shortcut most of it by walking us through the app and handing us Emily's existing FullStory/onboarding research. We're not starting from scratch.

From week three, we're building. Navigation trees, IA models, Figma mocks, then coded components. The deliverable at the end of 12 weeks is something you can ship - not a research deck.

Development may have a delayed start, but during the Build period, design and development will work to ensure designs are ready for development. Following are the Design and Development engagements separated, but our team will work together throughout the project.

12-Week Design Engagement

Scope: IA, Navigation, and Foundational Build

Goal: Redesign the information architecture and navigation system, implement it in the product, and establish the structural foundation that everything else - AI coach, persona differentiation, future products - gets built on top of.

Core team: UX, UI design, Development, Strategy, all embedded in the Vanilla team from day one.

Weeks 1–2: Discovery (Fast)

We come in, get up to speed quickly on what exists, and identify the handful of things that will move the needle most.

UX:

- Guided walkthrough of the live app with Alex and Joel - we map every navigation entry point, dead end, and persona mismatch as we go
- Ingest Emily's existing FullStory heat maps and onboarding analysis - we're not re-running research that's already been done
- Plot the four persona journeys (Advisor, Associate, Estate Planning Specialist, End Client) against the current nav structure - where does each persona get lost, hit a wall, or end up in the wrong place?
- Audit settings distribution - where are configuration options buried, duplicated, or missing entirely?
- Identify the category-vs-workflow navigation conflict Gene raised - document it concretely so we can resolve it in week three, not debate it indefinitely

Output by end of week 2:

- Current-state navigation map - every entry point, pathway, dead end documented
- Persona-friction map - where each user type breaks down in the current structure
- Five or six prioritised problem areas to address, ranked by user impact

Weeks 3–5: IA + Navigation Architecture

UX and dev work in parallel here - UX is designing the new system.

UX:

- Resolve the category-vs-workflow navigation debate with a concrete recommendation, not a list of options. We'll have enough context by week three to make a call

- Design the new top-level information architecture - unified, extensible, built to support estate planning now and tax/retirement/investments later without a structural rebuild
- Design the persona-adaptive navigation model - a single nav system that surfaces the right entry points and tools per role, without requiring separate UI shells per persona. This directly supports the roles/permissions work Larry's team is already building
- Produce annotated IA document: full content taxonomy, hierarchy, labelling decisions, rationale
- Produce navigation model in Figma: top-level structure, secondary navigation, settings consolidation, key workflow entry points for each persona
- First-pass design of the universal input/output pattern for AI-populated vs. manually-populated fields - the foundation for fixing the dead zones Sam flagged. Not fully built yet, but the design decisions locked so dev can build to spec

Output by end of week 5:

- New IA document (annotated, rationale included, ready for Larry and Gene to review)
- Figma: full navigation model, persona-adaptive structure, settings consolidation
- Figma: universal AI/manual input pattern (design spec)

Weeks 6–10: Build

UX and dev will work concurrently. Comedia Design is finalizing component-level designs one or two sprints ahead of development.

UX:

- Finalise Figma component specs for all new navigation elements - nav bars, sidebar structure, top-level routing, settings panel, breadcrumbs/wayfinding
- Design the first-time user experience / empty state flows - the onboarding problem Gene and Sam both called out. What does an advisor see when they log in with no clients yet? What's the guided path to first value?
- Design the persona entry points in detail - what the Advisor dashboard looks like vs. the Associate view vs. the Specialist view, driven by the same underlying IA but surfacing different tools and priorities
- Design the AI/manual input component in full - the consistent pattern for any field or section that can be populated by V/AI or entered manually, with clear visual states for each (AI-populated, manually entered, pending review, conflicted). This is the dead zones fix
- Annotate all Figma files for dev handoff - interaction states, edge cases, error states, loading states. No ambiguity in the specs

Output rolling through weeks 6–10 (shown at Thursday show-and-tells):

- New navigation - built and functional in branch

- Persona entry points - built and functional
- AI/manual input component - built, documented, in component library
- Consolidated settings panel - built and functional
- First-time user / empty state experience - built and functional

Weeks 11–12: Test, Tighten, Merge

UX:

- Walk each persona journey end-to-end in the branch build - does it hold up against the problems we documented in week one?
- QA against Figma specs - flag anything that drifted during build
- Write UX documentation: design decisions, component usage guidelines, rationale for IA choices - so the Vanilla development team can extend the system confidently without us in the room

Output by end of week 12:

- All new nav, IA, persona entry points, AI input pattern, and settings consolidation
- Full Figma source files handed over
- UX documentation
- Prioritized list of next-phase work (seeds Phase 2 if Vanilla wants to continue)

12-Week Development Engagement

Scope: Foundational Build

Goal: Understand the technical environment for the redesign of the information architecture and navigation system.

Core team: Development

Weeks 1–2: Discovery (Fast)

Dev:

Comedia is already familiar with the core technology — React, Tailwind, and GraphQL — so there's no ramp-up time on the stack itself. Discovery is focused on understanding Vanilla's specific implementation and scoping the full extent of the IA changes required.

- Comedia will develop in the same core technology as listed above
- Further codebase walkthrough with Larry's team - understand the frontend architecture, component library, routing conventions, state management patterns

- Map which nav and layout elements are currently hardcoded vs. driven by permissions/roles - this determines how much of the new IA can be implemented cleanly vs. what needs refactoring
- Identify any technical constraints that should inform the IA decisions before we commit to an architecture (e.g. how the roles/permissions system currently surfaces content)

Output by end of week 2:

- Dev constraint - what's technically load-bearing, what's flexible, what would need refactoring to support the new model

Weeks 3–5: IA + Navigation Architecture

Dev is setting up the foundation.

Dev:

- Set up the feature branch - clean separation from the 30 people shipping daily
- Audit and document the existing frontend component library relevant to navigation and layout (nav bars, sidebars, menus, modals, routing wrappers)
- Identify reusable components vs. what needs to be built net-new based on the new IA direction coming out of UX
- Start building out the new routing structure in the branch so it's ready to receive components as Irene finalises designs in weeks 4–5, with checkpoints built in along the way

Output by end of week 5:

- Frontend scaffold in branch: new routing structure, component inventory

Weeks 6–10: Build

UX and dev will work concurrently. Design is finalizing component-level designs one or two sprints ahead of Dev building them. Comedia shall incorporate feature flags on all new code, provide frequent PRs as reasonably requested by Client, and allow for routine code reviews by Client.

Dev:

- Build the new navigation components in the feature branch - top nav, sidebar, routing, active states, responsive behaviour
- Implement the persona-adaptive layer - nav renders differently based on role/permissions, using the permissions infrastructure Larry's team is building. Ben coordinates with Larry's team to make sure we're building on top of their permissions model, not creating a parallel one

- Build the universal AI/manual input component - the reusable pattern Irene has specced. This becomes a shared component in the library that Larry's team can use going forward
- Wire the new nav structure into the four primary persona entry points - Advisor, Associate, Specialist, End Client each land in the right place with the right tools visible
- Build the consolidated settings panel - centralize what's currently scattered across the app
- Weekly show-and-tells from week 6 onwards - working builds shared with Larry and the team each Thursday to keep everyone aligned as the work progresses

Output rolling through weeks 6–10 (shown at Thursday show-and-tells):

- New navigation - built and functional in branch
- Persona entry points - built and functional
- AI/manual input component - built, documented, in component library
- Consolidated settings panel - built and functional
- First-time user / empty state experience - built and functional

Weeks 11–12: Test, Tighten, Merge

Dev:

While QA, performance checks, and documentation are woven throughout the entire build, this phase is about tying everything together:

- Cross-browser and responsive QA. Latency and responsiveness will not degrade from today's experience. After completion of this SOW including User Acceptance Testing, Acceptance, and warranty period, Comedia shall not be responsible for any features deployed, infrastructure changes, or changes to Comedia's work that affect latency or responsiveness.
- Performance check on new routing and component rendering
- Address any issues surfaced by UX walkthrough
- Code documentation - inline comments, component API documentation
- There will not be one large merge at the end, incremental delivery along the project is required. Execute merge and support any integration issues

Output by end of week 12:

- All new nav, IA, persona entry points, AI input pattern, and settings consolidation merged to production
- Prioritised list of next-phase work (seeds Phase 2 if Vanilla wants to continue)

Timeline: April 2026 start

Implementation Approach

Before build starts, Comedia will present Vanilla's team with three implementation options for how the IA changes are introduced into the live codebase:

- **Feature flags** — new IA built behind a flag in the main branch, rolled out incrementally
- **Incremental component swap** — nav components replaced one at a time directly in main

Each option has different tradeoffs around merge risk, team disruption, and rollout control. We'll walk through the tradeoffs with Vanilla's team and agree the approach before build begins.

Our recommendation going in is a combination of incremental delivery and feature flags.

This keeps the work visible to Vanilla's team throughout, avoids a high-risk big-bang merge, and allows the new IA to be rolled out quietly rather than switched on for everyone at once. But we want to make this decision with Vanilla, not for them.